

FOREIGN AFFAIRS | China

THE SMOKELESS WAR: China's secret strategy to replace America as a global superpower. Implications for India and the world

BEWARE OF THE DRAGON

The one topic of discussion that has dominated global geopolitical discourse is the rise of China and its hegemonic ambition. The main reason behind China's current dominance in various fields, believes author and China expert Michael Pillsbury, is that, for years, the US preferred China over India, transferred latest technology, invested heavily in it and helped the one-party nation grow by leaps and bounds. Conversely, the US blocked high-end technologies to India for decades. This skewed state of affairs is slowly changing, though the US is still investing in China, said Pillsbury. So, while an "India moment" is important, the "China moment" is still not a spent force, feels Pillsbury, who has authored *The Hundred-Year Marathon: China's Secret Strategy to Replace America as the Global Superpower*. The Chinese, he said, have pulled ahead of the US in the areas of space technology, missile technology and biotechnology, but are extremely cautious not to brag about it. Strategically, too, the Chinese were thinking way ahead—even 20 years in advance—to patiently frame and plan what they needed to do to be a global superpower. Pillsbury said that though there is a debate in China about whether President Xi Jinping has been too open in expressing China's ambitions, the country is very sensitive about the 'China threat' theory growing across the world.

Contradicting him, Manoj Kewalramani, Fellow, China Studies, and Chairperson at the Indo-Pacific Studies Programme at Takshashila Institution, pointed out that there is still a large difference between China and the US vis-à-vis power projection and diplomatic heft. He believes that Beijing's ability to project comprehensive power beyond its immediate neighbourhood is extremely limited. ■

> I don't think a Chinese invasion of Taiwan is inevitable soon...it would be extremely foolhardy, particularly after the lessons Xi Jinping is watching Russia learn in Ukraine
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> **Xi is no longer downplaying what he believes he wants the world order to be like. But I don't think he has the capability to achieve those goals of dominance**
>
> **MANOJ KEWALRAMANI**
> *Fellow, China Studies, and Chairperson, Indo-Pacific Studies Programme, Takshashila Institution*

